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E&I TASK FORCE NEWSLETTER

SWIB
STATE OF WISCONSIN INVESTMENT BOARD

WHAT IS THE E&I TASK FORCE?

This year, SWIB formed the Equity and Inclusion (E&I) Task Force, which is dedicated to establishing and promoting a diverse and respectful workforce and a culture committed to equity and inclusion. The group is made up of 12 staff members from across the agency. The Task Force has met several times already this year and has established a set of goals for 2021. Initially, the Task Force will be focused on creating awareness of SWIB's current practices that promote equity and inclusion, developing, tracking and reporting on relevant diversity metrics, vetting potential training opportunities and other resources to roll out to staff, and connecting into the values work already underway at SWIB.

The Task Force is an important opportunity to build and advance SWIB's People Value, which reminds us to "respect, appreciate and accept all SWIB employees and are committed to cultivating and preserving a diverse and inclusive workplace." SWIB believes that when employees feel comfortable and confident in voicing their ideas, providing feedback, and speaking up, this greater diversity of thought drives innovation and better business decisions and enhances our ability to attract, develop, retain, and engage highly talented employees.

The Task Force plans to use this newsletter to communicate its ongoing work on a regular basis and to develop a SWIBNet page to provide relevant content. To learn more about SWIB's commitment to E&I, please see the Workforce Equity and Inclusion Philosophy.

Equity and Inclusion (E&I) Task Force

Creating a workplace committed to diversity, equity, and inclusion

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PEOPLE

WHY ARE PREFERRED PRONOUNS IMPORTANT IN THE WORKPLACE?

One topic that came up in an early meeting of the E&I Task Force was the use of preferred pronouns. Preferred pronouns are the pronouns you choose to use for yourself that help to identify your gender expression. There are a multitude of preferred pronouns, but the ones you are most likely to come across are she/her, he/him, and they/them. The use of pronouns is commonplace in conversation but asking for, remembering and using a person's preferred pronouns is a positive way to show respect and support for your colleagues and create a more welcoming environment. You may not always be able to determine the pronouns someone chooses to use just by looking at them or seeing their name come across in an email. SWIB wants staff to feel comfortable when they come to work each day, and for the office to be a place of inclusivity and respect.

How do I include my pronouns in my email signature?
In Outlook, click File and then Options, then select Mail from the menu on the left-hand side. Choose Create or Modify Signatures. Select the signature you would like to edit, type your preferred pronouns under your name in the same font style as your name – Times New Roman, and click Okay on the bottom right. Along with adding pronouns to your email signature, this is a good opportunity to confirm you're using the SWIB branded signature, which matches the following example:

Brenna Stevens
she/her
Multimedia Communications Specialist

SWIB STATE OF WISCONSIN INVESTMENT BOARD

121 E. Wilson St.
P.O. Box 7842
Madison, WI 53707
(608) 261-2381
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FAQ

How do I respectfully ask for someone's pronouns?
You can first look for preferred pronouns in email signatures or LinkedIn profiles.Otherwise, you can always ask someone "What pronouns do you prefer?" while in conversation. It may be useful to ask all members in a meeting to introduce themselves with their name and pronouns.

What do I do if I make a mistake?
The best and most respectful way to navigate a situation where you've used the incorrect pronouns for someone is to apologize and correct yourself. Making mistakes is human, and the proper way to address a mistake is to move forward with respect and inclusivity.

How do I include my pronouns on LinkedIn?
In LinkedIn, go to your profile. Click the pencil tool on the right-hand side of your profile to edit. LinkedIn now includes a designated section for pronouns, so you can select your choice from the drop-down menu and then choose your preferred visibility. Hit save to finalize your choices.

Does SWIB require that I include my pronouns in email or LinkedIn?
No. You are free to include or not include pronouns as you choose.

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METRICS

HR with the assistance of the Task Force has developed a new employee self-identification form to help us track our diversity metrics over time. While SWIB has always had a voluntary employee questionnaire that all new employees complete, the Task Force believed it could be enhanced, more inclusive, and provide more information. We will ask all new employees to fill this out as well as ask all current staff to complete the new survey. Completing the form is voluntary but we encourage everyone to participate. Individual employee information will be maintained and held confidentially by HR and will not be shared on an individual basis. However, the information will be aggregated for reporting purposes to provide transparency and insight. More information will be forthcoming about the form and the timeline for completing it.

EQUITY AND INCLUSION IN SWIB'S INTERN RECRUITING

SWIB's Recruiting Division partners with diversity-focused organizations to help build a diverse pipeline of interns that bring a unique perspective to the organization. Every year, SWIB hires a team of talented and energetic students for a rewarding summer experience filled with challenging, real-world projects. Recruiting works with the following organizations to promote diversity in the intern program:

Toigo Foundation: Fosters the career advancement and increased leadership of underrepresented talent by creating mechanisms for greater inclusion from the classroom to the boardroom.

Forte Foundation: Launches women into fulfilling, significant careers through access to business education, professional development, and a community of successful women.

The University of Maryland, Baltimore County Meyerhoff Scholar Program: At the forefront of efforts to increase diversity among future leaders in science, engineering, and related fields.

The University of Chicago, John W. Rogers, Jr. Internship Program in Finance: Provides career resources and funded internship opportunities for students interested in financial services careers and seeks to promote diversity within the field. SWIB has participated the past three summer program sessions to host an Equities intern.

RippleMatch: SWIB's newest relationship launched in September 2021, promoting SWIB internships at 73 Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) as well as 97 Hispanic-Serving Institutions (HSIs).

Dedicated diversity efforts have already shown results. Since 2019, female representation in SWIB's internship program has grown from 32% to 53% in 2020 and 46% in 2021, and ethnic diversity from 21% to 50% in 2021. We report these metrics to the Board each year as well as report our new hire diversity metrics to the Board quarterly.

SWIB's diverse intern recruitment creates a long-term hiring pipeline for SWIB as we increase our network of alumni interns and their contacts. We believe that investing in diversity in the intern program each year will ultimately lead to more diversity in SWIB's full time staff.

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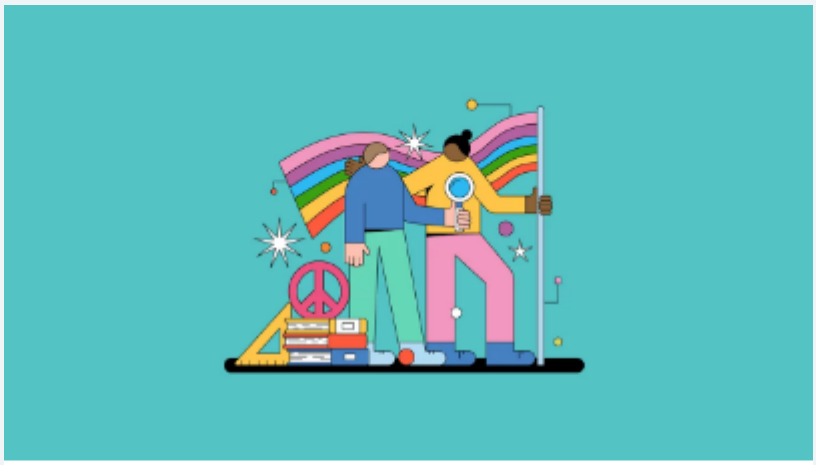
FOOD FOR THOUGHT

The Task Force researched and reviewed articles on E&I as a team. Here were a few that we thought staff would find interesting and thought provoking.

What Does it Take to Build a Culture of Belonging?

Four concrete actions leaders can take.



Research: What Inclusive Companies Have in Common

Data from a survey of 19,000 HBR readers.

DEFINITIONS

courtesy of McGill University

Diversity

Describes the presence of difference within any collection of people. In discussions of social equity, diversity addresses differences in social group membership related, for example, to race, Indigenous identity, class, gender identity or expression, sexuality, ability, ethnicity, and religion. Discussions about diversity linked to access and equity require knowledge and understanding of historical and contemporary experiences of oppression and exclusion.

Equity

Unlike the notion of equality, is not about sameness of treatment. Equity denotes fairness and justice in process and in results. Equitable outcomes often require differential treatment and resource redistribution so as to achieve a level playing field among all individuals and communities. This requires recognizing and addressing barriers to to provide opportunity for all individuals and communities to thrive in our environment. Several variations on the images shown below are sometimes used to illustrate the meaning and implications of equity.

Inclusion

Refers to the notion of belonging, feeling welcome, having a sense of citizenship, and the capacity to engage and succeed in a given institution, program, or setting. Inclusion calls for recognizing, reducing, and removing barriers to participation and belonging, sometimes entailing the change or reimagination of such institutions, programs, or settings. Inclusion means welcoming and valuing all members of our University community.

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IN THEIR OWN WORDS

Hear from the Task Force on their committment to diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives.

Stefano Cavaglia

"We should be free to respectfully express our identity - be it ethnically, sexually, intellectually, or otherwise determined. Anyone who has been made an 'outcast' due to their identity has experienced daggers to the soul and the mind. Recognizing, respecting, and elevating diversity will foster our human and creative spirit. This is why I joined the Task Force...it is for the greater good."

Andrea Ruiz

"I am excited to be a part of the Task Force because I believe these efforts will result in a more productive, engaged, and diverse team at SWIB. That in turn will lead to a better investment performance of the assets we manage and a better outcome for the participants."

Rochelle Klaskin

"Belief in the value of diversity, equity, and inclusion comes right from the top at SWIB. The Management Council is focused on creating a positive and welcoming work environment that supports our culture and contributes to our success and our well-being. I am proud and excited to chair the Task Force."

Questions, Comments, or Suggestions?

Have a question, comment, or suggestion? How about an interesting article, podcast, or video on equity and inclusion topics? Please feel free to reach out to any member of the E&I Task Force.